FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Terror had not touched Delhi for over 14 years. The last major incident was the 2011 bomb blast outside the Delhi High Court that left 12 dead and 91 injured. Even other big Indian cities have been incident-free since the Hyderabad blasts of 2013. That long lull was shattered on November 10, 6:55 pm. A surveillance camera captured the moment: a busy Monday evening, traffic crawling through the smog, then a fireball engulfing the screen. An explosive-laden Hyundai i20 had detonated in front of the iconic Red Fort. Preliminary scans found no shrapnel, timer or wiring. Instead, as investigators put together the pieces, what took shape was a different sort of circuitry. They are calling it the White Collar Terror network. A new infrastructure of radicalised professionals, doctors in this case, highly educated and equally highly committed to the path of violence. The lines, troublingly, trace back to Kashmir. And, even if investigators were chary of saying it plainly, to one of India's chief tormentors: Pakistan-based terror outfit Jaish-e-Mohammed.

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The immediate chain of causation linked the blast to a security operation a few days before. A 'Faridabad module' had been busted, with nearly 3,000 kg of explosives and bomb-making material, enough to set off several deadly explosions. Equally striking were the characters caught in the dragnet: a full panel of terror doctors, as it were. It was an alert Senior Superintendent of Police in the J&K Police, coincidentally also a doctor in Andhra Pradesh before he joined the IPS, who averted the bigger peril. The unravelling started around October 18, when warning posters from Jaish appeared on walls in Nowgam, uptown Srinagar. CCTV footage led, via the footsoldiers, to a radical imam. He spilled the beans on an interstate network: indoctrinated doctors, serving in satellite towns around Delhi, communicating on encrypted channels like Telegram, plotting asymmetric war.

Things moved swiftly; arrests and seizures between November 6-10 neutralised much of the network. But there was one missing link: Dr Umar un-Nabi. It was he who triggered the car bomb outside Red Fort, killing himself along with 12 civilians and injuring 20 others. CCTV footage suggests design rather than accident. He had parked nearby for three hours, come out to join peak hour traffic, passed a metro station and two temples, sites with potential for far greater havoc, and taken a U-turn back to a site of high symbolic value.

The incident leaves plenty for India's security bosses to rethink. After the April massacre at Pahalgam, India launched Operation Sindoor, hitting directly at terror infrastructure in Pakistan. One of its high-profile targets was the Jaish headquarters in Bahawalpur. Even through the triumphalism seen during the summer conflict, there had been apprehensions. The Jaish was bound to be smarting from the humiliation. Moreover, many family members of supremo Masood Azhar had been killed in the attacks. As videos of Jaish commanders made evident, revenge was a clear and present danger. Even before Op Sindoor, they had been quietly indoctrinating, raising and training this new white-collar terror army. October's Nowgam raids unearthed a vital collateral clue: an internal Jaish letter dated October 17, full of dire warnings to local operatives against leaking information. Clearly, the counter-insurgency pressure was high in Kashmir.

All the clues converge on a few key inferences. Pakistan has shifted its strategy from brazen Pahalgam-style attacks, using infiltrators trained on its soil. By fostering and radicalising educated professionals in the Valley to act as its sword-arm, Pakistan achieves three aims. It gets much higher plausible deniability. Pointing to 'homegrown' actors helps its global narrative of Kashmir's disillusionment with the Indian state. Besides, their professional roles confer a beguiling cover that helps throw off security agencies. It's not unusual for intellectuals or the well-to-do to be indoctrinated. What's different this time is that they have gone beyond being ideologues or sponsors. They are hands-on executors of terror and, as Nabi has shown, even willing to be fidayeen.

India, too, has altered its strategy post Pahalgam, when it found that global support for Op Sindoor, particularly from America, was lukewarm. So, instead of proclaiming on the first day that it saw Islamabad's hand, it has gone about quietly investigating the case to build up hard evidence to prove it. To nail Pakistan's complicity, building an indisputable chain of evidence is essential. Show rather than tell, especially to the international community. That's what will sanctify the punishment, the promise the Modi government had made after Pahalgam that every new act of terror would invite a military response.

In the days ahead, it is imperative that a nationwide hunt roots out all such white-collar modules. Internal security must be beefed up, particularly in major metros. Our cover story this week unmasks this chilling new face of terror, examining how educated professionals have been weaponised and what it means for our security apparatus. It also gives New Delhi an occasion to review its Kashmir policy and plug gaps. Clarity of purpose demands tactical awareness of when and where hard action is required, or not. Terror, like history, has a way of returning when least expected. This time, it wears a white coat.

(Aroon Purie)